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The Mughal Empire

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CHAPTER 7

THE WAR OF SUCCESSION

During the last half of Shah Jahan's reign a long-standing political and intellectual conflict in the Mughal empire polarized around the two most able and forceful Mughal princes. The liberal party found an articulate and influential spokesman in the eldest son of Shah Jahan. Prince Dara Shukoh attracted those nobles, imperial officers, scholars, intellectuals, and others who remained committed to Akbar's eclectic ideology and policies. The conservative party found its champion in Shah Jahan's third son. Aurangzeb drew to him Muslim nobles, officers, theologians, official ulema who wished to shift the empire toward a more properly Muslim state in conformity with the Sharia. The latter drew their confidence from an increasingly visible revivalist movement within Indian Islam. By the 1640s and 1650s other major policy issues such as the question of Deccan conquest and Mughal relations with Bijapur and Golconda were drawn into this rivalry.

The two princes emerged as spokesmen in part because of their high rank, status, and patronage they disposed. In reality, however, Dara Shukoh and Aurangzeb were important because of the future. One of Shah Jahan's four sons, all mature men, would win the inevitable struggle for succession and Dara and Aurangzeb were the most likely candidates to prevail. Murad and Shuja, the other two brothers, while competent administrators and generals, were generally seen as weaker candidates for the throne. Neither had adopted such pronounced ideological positions as did Dara or Aurangzeb.

Dara Shukoh remained at court in close personal contact with the emperor. As the favorite and heir-apparent, he greatly influenced the emperor. His greatest ally was his eldest sister the princess Jahan Ara, who served as mistress of the royal household after the death of her mother, Mumtaz Mahal.

In his intellectual curiosity, his open-mindedness, and his mystical interests Dara was in many ways a throwback to his great-grandfather, Akbar. He was an active disciple of Mulla Mir (d. 1635)

and Mulla Shah Badakshi (d. 1661) two leading Shaikhs of the Qadiri order of Sufis.¹ In the earliest phase of his mystical studies the prince compiled a hagiography of Sufi saints and a recounting of orthodox mystical beliefs.

Beginning in 1641 the maturing scholar, following the Koranic injunction that no land has been left without prophetic guidance, became convinced that the Vedas and the Upanishads constitute the concealed scripture mentioned in the Koran. He regarded the Upanishads as the ultimate source of all monotheism, including Islam. With the aid of Brahmin scholars in his employ, Dara translated the fifty-two Upanishads into Persian in a work titled *Sirr-i Akbar*. In a subsequent Persian work titled *Majma' al-bahrayn* "The Mingling of the Two Oceans," the scholar-prince argued that the essential nature of Hinduism was identical to that of Islam. Using techniques of lexical similarity Dara posited that the cosmologies and mystical practices of Muslim Sufis and those of the Upanishads correspond. For example, *ruh* or "soul" in Islam is equivalent to *atman* in Vedantic Hinduism. The Sufi concept of love is the same as the Hindu notion of *maya* or illusion. Dara had "The Mingling of the Two Oceans" translated into Sanskrit under the title *Samudra Sangam* to make it accessible to Hindu scholars.

The prince only succeeded in persuading most Indian Muslims that he was an apostate who cavalierly ignored the obligatory prayers and other rituals of Islam. Extended discussions with and patronage of three Jesuit priests who formed part of his household confirmed this impression. Conversations with the Hindu Bhakti saint Babalal Vairagi had a similar effect. Although it is likely that Dara remained a convinced monotheist, the appearance of apostasy left him politically vulnerable to attack by the ulema.

Despite his intellectual gifts, Dara Shukoh was a mediocre general and an insensitive leader who failed to strike the right air of authority and sympathy with nobles. The most powerful amirs of the realm were reportedly insulted by his excessive pride and haughtiness.²

Aurangzeb, Shah Jahan's third son with Mumtaz Mahal, was of an

¹ The following discussion of Dara Shukoh is drawn from Aziz Ahmad, "Dara Shikoh and Aurangzeb" an essay appearing in Aziz Ahmad, *Studies in Islamic Culture in the Indian Environment* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1964), pp. 191-200.

² N. Manucci, *Storia do Mogor or Mogul India* (Calcutta, 4 vols., 1907-8), translated by William Irvine; 1, 221-226 for an account of Dara's flaws and the enemies he made.

entirely different personality. Niccolao Manucci's eyewitness description is apt:³

This prince was very different from the others, being in character very secretive and serious, carrying on his affairs in a hidden way, but most energetically. He was of a melancholy temperament, always busy at something or another, wishing to execute justice and arrive at appropriate decisions. He was extremely anxious to be recognized by the world as a man of wisdom, clever and a lover of the truth. He was moderately liberal, distributing rewards and conferring gifts wherever suitable. But above all, for a long time he pretended to be a faquir (*faqir*), a holy mendicant, by which he renounced the world, gave up all claim to the crown, and was content to pass his life in prayers and mortifications.

Aurangzeb obviously was a man of extreme piety, who punctiliously observed the public rituals of Islam. He did not drink wine or take opium. Engaged in his own spiritual quest, Aurangzeb held long discussions with members of the ulema or shaikhs from the orthodox Naqshbandi order. He avidly read the Koran, treatises on the law, and the works of Al-Ghazzali and other prominent Islamic scholars. But Aurangzeb's piety, as suggested by Manucci, did not interfere with his worldly ambition or continual maneuvering in the high politics of empire.

An experienced military commander and administrator, Aurangzeb served as governor of the Mughal Deccan for eight years; as governor of Gujarat for three years, and then as commander of Mughal armies in the invasion of Balkh and the first two sieges of Qandahar fort. Despite his devoted and able performance in these offices, Aurangzeb's relationship with his father was acrimonious and distant. Shah Jahan, encouraged by Dara Shukoh and Jahan Ara, rebuked his least favourite son frequently, and often unfairly, for a variety of shortcomings. Aurangzeb's principal ally in the imperial household was his elder sister Raushan Ara Begam, the fourth child of Mumtaz Mahal. She sent him a constant flow of information about the emperor and court politics.

In 1652, after the third Qandahar campaign ended ignominiously under Dara's command, Shah Jahan assigned Aurangzeb to administer the Deccan provinces once more. For the next five years polarized tensions in the empire centered on the political struggle between Dara at court and Aurangzeb in the Deccan.

³ Manucci, *Storia*, I, 229.

THE MUGHAL EMPIRE

CONFLICT OVER THE DECCAN

Shah Jahan sent Aurangzeb to the south enjoined to reform and restore an effective imperial administration. Since Aurangzeb's departure in 1644, a succession of ineffective governors, corrupt officials, destructive military campaigns, and poor agricultural seasons had reduced the productive capacity of the region. Many villages were deserted and areas formerly cultivated were now forested. Every year a shortfall in imperial revenues forced Shah Jahan to send a subsidy to meet the expenses of the Deccan military and administrative establishment.

Under Aurangzeb's capable direction the famed revenue officer Murshid Quli Khan restored order and predictability to the imperial agrarian system (see above). To stimulate cultivation Murshid Quli Khan advanced large loans in Khandesh and Berar for peasants to repair and expand riverine irrigation. In all four provinces he induced energetic men to become headmen and settle abandoned villages by making various tax concessions.⁴

Imperial revenues began to increase, but not enough to compensate for the deficit. Aurangzeb and Shah Jahan wrangled continually over Aurangzeb's request for additional funds to be transferred from Malwa and Gujarat. In an increasingly acrimonious correspondence, Aurangzeb claimed the 800,000 rupee annual tribute from Golconda as well. Caught in his budgetary difficulties Aurangzeb pressed his father for permission to invade and annex the Sultanate of Golconda. Golconda was renowned in the seventeenth century world for its wealth and especially for its rich diamond mines. Shah Jahan, who still bore friendly feelings toward Abdullah Qutb Shah for refuge taken during his own revolt as a prince, ruled out invasion. Undeterred, however, Aurangzeb began a secret exchange of letters with Muhammad Said, Mir Jumla, the Qutb Shahi conqueror of the Karnatak. This initiative brought together two of the most remarkable figures of the seventeenth century.

MUHAMMAD SAID, MIR JUMLA

The tributary status imposed on Bijapur and Golconda in 1636 stabilized the northern frontier of those states and brought a respite from Mughal invasion. A fixed policy aim of the Adil Shahi and Qutb

⁴ Jadunath Sarkar, *History of Aurangzib* (Calcutta, 5 vols., 1912-1924), I, 187-194.

Shahi rulers was to prevent by persuasion or bribery an aggressive Mughal forward policy in the Deccan. Their northern frontiers secured by treaty, each ruler was free to expand to the south.

In the southeastern plain and upland area called the Karnatak, political power was fragmented among a number of Telugu and Tamil *nayaks* who were the descendants of the great warrior nobles of Vijayanagara. Bijapur armies under Shahji Bhonsla, now in Adil Shahi service, and other Afghan and Maratha generals forcibly annexed lands from the Palar river, sixty miles south of Madras, to the Kaveri river in the Chola heartland. The latter became a province known as the Bijapur Karnatak. These conquests extended the frontier of Muslim power five hundred kilometers toward the tip of the subcontinent.

In the 1640s large armies from Golconda battered down local resistance and conquered the Karnatak between the Krishna river in the north and the Palar river. This rich, fertile area, also known as the Coromandel coast, was the center of a burgeoning textile industry. Thousands of weavers, dyers, and other craftsmen produced millions of yards of cloth for growing overseas markets.

The architect of this triumph was Muhammad Said, a man of extraordinary talents. Born the son of an oil merchant in Iran, the young Muhammad Said migrated to Golconda in the employ of an Iranian trader. Soon the young entrepreneur obtained a lucrative diamond mining concession at the famed Golconda mines and rapidly became a prominent member of the group of Persian traders and shipowners in Golconda. Domiciled in either Hyderabad or the chief port, Machhilipatnam, these men were closely linked with their fellow Persians in the ruling elite of Golconda and held a commanding position in the kingdom's maritime trade.⁵

By 1634 Muhammad Said, who is credited with unusual organizational skills and personal appeal, had opted for the larger prizes associated with official power in Golconda. Under what has been called a system of "political capitalism" Muslim officials in Golconda at all levels were heavily involved in commerce and shipowning.⁶ They used political power to improve their commercial interests by a variety of monopoly devices. Within a short time, Muhammad Said became governor of the port of Machhilipatnam and other coastal territories.

⁵ Jagdish Narayan Sarkar, *The Life of Mir Jumla* (Delhi: Rajesh Publications, 2nd. revised edition, 1979), pp. 4-5.

⁶ Sinnappah Arasaratnam, *Merchants, Companies, and Commerce on the Coromandel Coast 1650-1740* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1986), pp. 225-225.

Retaining these offices under his agents, in 1638 he rose to chief minister of the kingdom and received the title of Mir Jumla.

In his handling of the Karnatak invasion in the early 1640s Mir Jumla proved to be a talented military strategist and diplomat. For ten years (1642–1652) his armies were engaged against the citadels of decentralized Hindu warriors and their troops. His formidable cavalry, infantry and artillery stormed even the most forbidding fortresses of the Hindu nayaks.

By 1652, Mir Jumla governed for Golconda the Hyderabad Karnatak – a kingdom nearly 40,000 square kilometers with annual revenues equivalent to four million rupees a year. His military role added greatly to his wealth. Plunder from looted Hindu temples and diamonds from the newly conquered alluvial diamond workings at Kullur (the richest in the world at the time) swelled his trading capital.⁷ Although he sent regular revenue payments north to Hyderabad a large share of the profits from the Golconda style tax farming system remained with him. The agents of Mir Jumla's growing commercial empire were found throughout the markets of the Mughal empire, in Persia, Mocha, Burma, Arakan, and Pegu. In addition to large herds of pack animals employed in the overland trade, Mir Jumla kept at least ten merchant vessels in commission plying between ports in the Bay of Bengal and in the Red Sea.

Perhaps not surprisingly, Mir Jumla ran afoul of his royal master, Abdullah Qutb Shah. Escaping an assassination plot by the Qutb Shah king, Mir Jumla turned to Bijapur and the Mughal empire to negotiate a position for himself and his newly founded domains in another state system.

AURANGZEB AND MIR JUMLA

Always alert to opportunity Aurangzeb opened a correspondence with Mir Jumla. The Deccan governor proposed to Mir Jumla that he hand over the Hyderabad Karnatak to Mughal rule and then attack Golconda from the south while Aurangzeb's armies invaded from the northwest. Mir Jumla accepted Aurangzeb's offer and became a collaborator in a plan to invade Golconda.

When in November, 1655, Abdullah Qutb Shah lost patience with Muhammad Amin, Mir Jumla's boorish son, his envoy at the Gol-

⁷ Sarkar, *Mir Jumla*, p. 77.

conda court, and placed him in confinement; this provided the pretext Aurangzeb needed to move Shah Jahan to action. The emperor enrolled Mir Jumla and his son as high-ranking Mughal amirs and ordered Abdullah Qutb Shah to release Muhammad Amin. Before the Golconda ruler received Shah Jahan's order, however, Aurangzeb had already sent an invading army into Golconda. The Mughal army easily occupied Hyderabad city while the Qutb Shah ruler and his court took refuge in Golconda fort where they were besieged by the Mughal army. Within two months Mir Jumla and his force arrived from the Karnatak to join Aurangzeb,

In the interim, Dara Shukoh and Jahan Ara had been approached at the Delhi court by agents of Abdullah Qutb Shah. The heir-apparent intervened and persuaded Shah Jahan to force Aurangzeb to withdraw. The Qutb Shah ruler would be forced to pay a large war indemnity, lose some border territory and give up a daughter for marriage to Muhammad Sultan, Aurangzeb's son. A peremptory order from the emperor left Aurangzeb, despite his protests, to withdraw.

By mid-year Mir Jumla had brought his entire establishment north to the imperial court at Shahjahanabad. At the unexpected death of the Mughal wazir, Shah Jahan conferred that office upon the newcomer with a one thousand zat increase in rank. Shah Jahan also agreed to treat the entire Hyderabad Karnatak as the jagir of his new minister and to send imperial officers to seize it from Golconda. For the first time Aurangzeb was favored with a powerful friend and advocate who rapidly obtained great influence over Shah Jahan. With this advocate Aurangzeb's policy of imperial aggression won the emperor's approval.

In November, 1656, Muhammad Adil Shah, who had been ill for a decade, died. His eighteen-year-old son, Ali Adil Shah II, faced a factious nobility and rebellious zamindars. Aurangzeb and Mir Jumla had for some time worked up a plan for the invasion of the kingdom as soon as the long-anticipated death of Muhammad Adil Shah occurred. Aurangzeb had been busy in suborning many of the nobles and military commanders in Bijapur service.

Shah Jahan approved an invasion and sent Mir Jumla with troops to assist. In mid-1657, as the Mughal army was poised to take Bijapur, the capital city, Shah Jahan, again urged by Dara Shukoh, ordered Aurangzeb to refrain from a final conquest. Instead he was forced to accept a large war indemnity and cession of the lands occupied to date. The

emperor ordered Mir Jumla to return to Delhi. In the midst of Aurangzeb's forced withdrawal, Shah Jahan fell ill in September, 1657. The first act of the great Mughal war of succession had begun.

THE WAR

Shah Jahan's magnificent reign ended in a long-anticipated, convulsive political crisis. When the emperor fell ill, pent-up tensions between the mature Timurid princes exploded into a four-sided war of succession. The war pitted Dara Shukoh, resident at court as the designated heir, against his three younger brothers: Muhammad Shuja, governor of Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa; Aurangzeb, governor of the four Deccan provinces; and Murad Bakhsh, governor of Gujarat and Malwa. All were sons of Mumtaz Mahal and therefore full, rather than half brothers. Despite Shah Jahan's expressed preference for his eldest son, Dara Shukoh, the Timurid appanage system offered no clear precedent for succession.

This was a bloody struggle fought by formidable opponents. Dara, Shuja, Aurangzeb, and Murad battled each other with that intensity and intimacy reserved to brothers with differing personalities. Each prince shared in the Timurid familial charisma and royal authority which gave all an undisputable claim on the throne. Each brother claimed long experience in war, statecraft, and administration and could draw upon the services of extremely able military and administrative staffs. Each commanded a power base, possessed ample treasure and could muster large, well-equipped armies. Only one contender could claim the throne; the others faced the grave.

When Shah Jahan failed to hold daily court audiences the news immediately swept to all parts of the empire. In Delhi the shops remained closed in the bazaars and public anxiety was at a high pitch for several days.⁸ Within the palace only Dara, his physicians, his daughter Janan Ara, and a few trusted officers were permitted to see the emperor. Dara quickly assumed command. He seized the agents and spies of his brothers and censored all communications between them and their masters. Shah Jahan's seclusion and Dara's censorship raised speculation that the emperor was either dead or completely helpless. After a month the emperor recovered sufficiently to appear in public.

⁸ Manucci, who served Dara Shukoh as a young gunner, gives a full description of the war from the viewpoint of a participant. Manucci, *Storia*, II, 229-386.

Thereafter the depressed and ailing emperor journeyed slowly to Agra to be near his wife's tomb.

In Bengal Prince Muhammad Shuja immediately crowned himself king at Rajmahal and brought his cavalry, artillery, and river flotilla upriver toward Agra. Near Varanasi his forces confronted a defending army sent from Delhi under the command of Prince Sulaiman Shukoh, son of Dara, and Raja Jai Singh. In mid-February, 1658, a well-executed early morning surprise attack routed the Bengal troops. Shuja and his surviving men fled downriver to Monghyr.

To the south, in Gujarat, Murad Bakhsh immediately sent a 6,000 man force to extort a half-million rupee forced loan from the merchants of Surat and to besiege the fort whose commander (appointed independently by the emperor) refused to surrender. Rejecting reports of his father's recovery, on December 5th Murad crowned himself at a public ceremony. In early January Surat fort fell with its treasure and supplies and Murad prepared to march north.

In the Deccan the news reached Aurangzeb just as he was completing peace negotiations with the Sultan of Bijapur after a successful invasion of that kingdom. (see above).⁹ Between October and early January of 1658 Aurangzeb tried simultaneously to impose the punitive terms of the peace treaty on Bijapur and to position himself for a run for the throne. In contrast to Shuja and Murad, however, Aurangzeb did not take the irrevocable step of crowning himself. Instead, he engaged in a busy secret correspondence with Murad, and, to a lesser extent, with Shuja. Letters written in cipher encased in bamboo tubes passed from runner to runner over special relay posts newly established between Ahmadabad and Aurangabad. Within a few weeks Aurangzeb and Murad had agreed on a plan for joint action. If they defeated their brothers, Aurangzeb would leave to Murad the Punjab, Afghanistan, Kashmir, and Sind to rule as an independent king and he would rule the remaining territories. Simultaneously, carrying on a wide-ranging correspondence, Aurangzeb induced most of the higher ranking nobles of the Deccan to join him.

In early February 1658, Aurangzeb set his army marching north. He joined forces with Murad at the village of Dharmat on the Ghambira river. Here they met Shah Jahan's army under the command of Jaswant Singh Rathor. In the ensuing battle Aurangzeb's well-

⁹ Sarkar, *History of Aurangzib*, II, 278-79.

handled guns and cavalry outfought the imperial army whose survivors fell back on Delhi in disarray.¹⁰

At Delhi Dara rebuilt a 50,000 man army and awaited his brothers at defensive positions on the Chambal river south of Agra. Aurangzeb outflanked him by finding an unguarded ford. The armies met on a broad plain at the village of Samugarh on the Yamuna near Agra. On 29 May, in the blazing heat of Indian summer, the climactic battle of the succession struggle took place. Aurangzeb's superior tactics and better disciplined artillery and cavalry prevailed against the valor of repeated Rajput cavalry charges. Finally, toward the end of the day, Dara dismounted from his war elephant and fled the field on horseback. A full-scale rout began.

About nine in the evening Dara and a small group of his followers reached his mansion in Agra fort. Unwilling to face his father, he rested a few hours then fled toward Delhi accompanied by his family and a few retainers carrying his treasury. Aurangzeb occupied Agra city and, when negotiations failed, besieged his father in Agra fort. Deprived of access to water from the river, Shah Jahan surrendered on June 8, 1658 and became his son's prisoner. The vast treasuries and magazines of Agra fort fell into Aurangzeb's hands.

Dara stayed only briefly in Delhi before moving on to Lahore. When Aurangzeb resumed the pursuit, tension between him and Murad grew. Despite warnings, Murad entered his brother's camp for a dinner on 25 June. Here he was disarmed, made captive and quietly sent off to prison along with his son. Aurangzeb enrolled Murad's leaderless soldiery into his service the next day.

Aurangzeb paused in Delhi long enough to crown himself on 21 July in Shalimar gardens with the title of Alamgir or "world-seizer." This action marks the end of the first phase of the war of succession when the outcome was really in doubt. Thereafter Aurangzeb dealt with his brothers from an overwhelmingly strong position.

When Aurangzeb's army crossed the Sutlej river, Dara panicked and fled south down the Indus river with part of Aurangzeb's army in pursuit. At Bhakkar, a river fortification, he abandoned part of his troops, heavy guns, much of a ten-million rupee treasure, and many dependents. Dara fled south with a few retainers to the Arabian Sea where he finally took refuge in Gujarat.

By the end of September Aurangzeb left the tracking of Dara to his

¹⁰ Ibid., pp. 20-25.

officers to meet a new threat: his brother Shuja. Shuja, rejecting Aurangzeb's promises of unthreatened rule in the east, mustered a force of 25,000 cavalry and a flotilla of river boats and marched upriver. In late December Aurangzeb joined his son Muhammad Sultan for battle against Shuja. Despite the last-minute defection of Jaswant Singh Rathor with his Rajput cavalry to Shuja, Aurangzeb's army greatly outnumbered and outgunned the Bengal army. Defeated and routed, Shuja fled with the remnants of his army.

In the interim Dara had regained his courage, acquired funds, recruited a 20,000 man army in Gujarat, and marched north to liberate his father. When he reached Ajmer in Rajasthan the thousands of Rajput warriors promised to his cause by Jaswant Singh Rathor did not appear. Instead, Dara faced a large, well-equipped army commanded by his nemesis, his brother Aurangzeb. In mid-March, 1659, Aurangzeb's army overran Dara's forces in a bloody three-day battle fought in the hills outside Ajmer. Dara survived but fled once again.

On his return to Delhi Aurangzeb felt confident enough to arrange for a properly grand second coronation. On June 5, 1659, at an auspicious time, Aurangzeb sat on the throne in the Hall of Public Audience in the fortress at Shahjahanabad. A reciter read his names and titles as part of the khutba and newly struck coins were distributed. Only the aftermath of the war of succession remained.

Dara, put to flight again, spent the next three months as a wanderer trying to evade capture. From Gujarat, to the Rann of Kutch, to Seistan, to the Bolan Pass, he found little aid or comfort. Finally, he sought assistance from Malik Jiwan, an Afghan chief whose life he had saved from execution in Delhi some years before. His devoted wife, Nadira Banu, a Timurid princess, died of dysentery when they arrived. Dara sent her body off with most of his escort to be interred in Lahore. As soon as he did so, Malik Jiwan arrested Dara and sent word to his pursuers on the Indus.

When Dara Shukoh arrived at Delhi as a prisoner, Aurangzeb first had him paraded in public humiliation through the streets of the city. His appearance and his past generosity aroused much public sympathy. That evening in council Aurangzeb, his sister Raushan Ara, and his advisers, decided on a death sentence. The official ulema condemned Dara to death on grounds of apostasy from Islam and idolatry. On the night of August 30, 1659, two slaves killed Dara and his youngest son Sipihr Shukoh.

There followed a year-and-a-half-long, grim, water-borne campaign in pursuit of Prince Shuja by an imperial army under Mir Jumla. Shuja fought, retreated east and fought until, finally, at Tanda his army was decisively beaten and broken. In early May, 1660, Shuja left Dacca by boat with his family and a few faithful troops to take refuge with the raiding king of Arakan. Here, suspected of a plot against the king, he met his death.

Only Murad Bakhsh remained alive as a captive of Aurangzeb in the state prison at Gwalior fortress. In early 1661 a planned rescue by some of Murad's loyal Mughal officers failed, but he remained a threat. Rather than simply have Murad killed, Aurangzeb arranged a murder accusation. At the start of the war of succession, enraged with the suspicion that the diwan of Gujarat was an adherent of Shah Jahan, Murad had killed his fellow-officer with a spear-thrust. At Aurangzeb's instigation, the diwan's second son demanded justice under the Sharia for his father's death. The qazi of Gwalior fort tried the case and convicted Murad. The son refused to accept payment but asked for retribution. On December 4, 1661, two slaves carried out the execution.

The succession crisis reaffirmed the unity of the empire and the authority of the victorious Timurid monarch. Partition of the empire into two or more appanages did not take place. Division of the empire was a bargaining point, nothing more. The principals knew that whoever acquired the imperial capital and throne would not rest until the partitioned territories – be they in the east or west or south – were recovered. Ultimately the prize was access to a throne ruling a single, unitary empire.

Throughout Mughal India the succession struggle was high public drama. Movements of armies, alliances, battles, and skirmishes, the emperor's health, flights, and in the end, executions – all were of the most intense interest. Rumor and gossip darted across the bazaars of every town and city. Intelligence networks maintained by sarrafs, merchants, Sufi orders, and Hindu maths strained to obtain and transmit timely news. Relays of messengers on foot and horse traversed the roads of the empire. European traders collated and sent back reports to Europe on the crisis. Events thus shared suggest the degree to which the empire had become linked into a unified social system.

The 1658–59 war stretched the resources of a militarized state and society. The crisis disgorged a sizable portion of the great hoarded wealth of the empire found in the provincial and central treasuries and the personal holdings of nobles and officials. Spending on military needs soared as commanders on each side enlisted additional soldiery and bought supplies and munitions. Temporarily, at least, the civil war reversed the flow of revenues and accumulation of reserves. The normal flow of tax collections to the imperial center or to the designated jagir holders virtually dried up in the course of the war.

There were no noticeable or widespread uprisings by zamindars or peasants. Most of the countryside waited and watched for the outcome of events. Aurangzeb's early victories seem to have discouraged direct challenges to the regime. However, local revenue administration functioned but feebly for the duration of the conflict. The revenues of jagirdars and the imperial khalisa dried to a trickle. Agricultural production faltered as well when campaigning armies marched through the countryside. Unfortunately the ravages and dislocation of war were exacerbated by several years of scanty monsoon rains beginning in 1658. Throughout north and central India a general scarcity, amounting to famine conditions in many places, accompanied the political crisis. At Delhi, Agra, and Lahore drought-stricken peasants from the surrounding countryside descended on each city. The emperor and the amirs opened free kitchens to dispense cooked food in each city. Scarcity and the vast influx of dishoarded funds pressed prices to famine levels in the cities.¹¹

Timurid royal blood and ample funds were sufficient to recruit equipped, trained soldiers and obtain arms, animals, and military supplies in any part of the subcontinent. When in early 1659, Dara Shukoh arrived at Ahmadabad in Gujarat after his flight from Samugarh, his sympathizer, Shah Nawaz Khan, gave him one million rupees from Murad's treasury. With these funds Dara recruited some 20,000 cavalry and obtained forty artillery pieces within a month's time.¹² Everywhere soldiers and suppliers were fully employed.

By and large allegiances in this war were not determined by broader issues, but by pragmatism or personal loyalties. For the nobles and higher ranking mansabdars allegiance was often determined by the

¹¹ Shireen Mosvi, "Scarcities, Prices and Exploitation: The Agrarian Crisis, 1658–1670," *Studies in History* 1 (1985), 46–47.

¹² Sarkar, *History of Aurungzib*, II, 164–65.

vicissitudes of imperial posting. The degree of enthusiasm displayed by each noble might be determined by the personal appeal of the prince in question. For officers and men in private employment allegiance was determined by loyalty to one's salt or by lineage or clan loyalties to one's commanders. For those thousands of men in the floating pool of military manpower allegiance was a matter of payment and performance an amalgam of professional pride and the circumstance of battle and campaign.

The succession conflict did bring into the open serious political and religious divisions. At every opportunity Aurangzeb proclaimed his horror at Dara's apostacy from Islam and his idolatry. When Aurangzeb and Murad agreed to act jointly to divide the empire, the public, written statement affirmed that the proposed campaign was not simply a matter of personal power. Instead they had a more lofty aim: "to uproot the bramble of idolatry and infidelity from the realm of Islam and to overwhelm and crush the idolatrous chief [Dara] with his followers and strongholds."¹³

It is doubtful whether Aurangzeb's religious appeal swayed Muslim nobles to support him or caused Hindu nobles to turn against him. What we can assert, however, is that it did make a difference to the empire and its inhabitants which of the four contenders triumphed. Had Shuja or Murad won it is likely that they would have followed Shah Jahan's policies with few dramatic changes. Had Dara won, it is likely that a broader political appeal would have marked his reign. Whether he could have sustained this program in the face of a more conservative climate in both the Muslim and Hindu communities is another question that cannot be answered. Instead, Aurangzeb imposed a narrow, Islamic character on to the political culture of the empire. It was Aurangzeb's insistence on Islamic exclusivity that shaped imperial policy over the next half century.

¹³ Sarkar, *History of Aurangzib*, I, 335-337.